

CLUELESS IN WONDERLAND

Pop history meets half-baked scholarship in this wide-eyed discovery of India since the 1857 mutiny



VISHNU'S CROWDED TEMPLE: INDIA SINCE THE GREAT REBELLION

by MARIA MISRA
Allen Lane

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■ By Chandan Mitra

Maria Misra deserves 10/10 for sheer audacity. None but the hopelessly brave would even conceive of writing a tome on India between Bahadur Shah Zafar and Manmohan Singh in 450 hardback pages, that too, packaged as a scholarly publication. They say a very thin line separates bravado from foolhardiness. Misra treads that line with rare aplomb. And, thus, manages to confuse the reader about the category in which she should be placed. If raciness could substitute for academic rigour, the author would score yet another perfect 10, although she cannot aspire to more than a five on 10 for scholarship.

Her knowledge base, quite transparently, is second or third-hand, so she believes in leaving nothing out of her voluminous narrative. Thus, bazaar gossip and hearsay at Delhi's watering holes cohabit with dreary colonial dispatches, periodically adding spice to her haphazard account of India's evolution over the last 150 years. Purists may be somewhat puzzled by the slipshod research that characterises the volume and also the incoherence of the narration, which flits between time, space and personalities in a bewildering manner. If there was a category called a grasshopper's view of history, Misra's monograph would be eminently qualified to win a prize.

The author appears uncertain about the nature of her laborious project. Is it intended to be a university text-

book? Is it a scholarly contribution to the burgeoning body of Raj historiography? Is it a hybrid byproduct of a one-night stand between scholarship and pop history? Is there any particular reason why this book was written, except the hope that it may rake in considerable moolah once adequately promoted? I am no wiser after reading it.

Some anecdotes are admittedly quite funny, especially the one about Congress founder A.O. Hume. Apparently a "tactless" man with "cantankerous habits" and "the greatest liar who ever came to India" according to Raj accounts, Hume was drawn into politics under the influence of the charismatic Russian émigré, Madame Blavatsky. He attended a séance conducted by her Theosophical Society,

SECONDHAND SCHOLAR: The author's unfamiliarity with India is evident

during which a certain mahatma, Koot Hoomi Lal Singh, supposedly a deceased 1857 rebel, spoke to Hume, urging him to take up the cause of political reform. "Hume's commitment to the cause remained undeterred by the scandalous revelation that the bellicose mahatma was none other than the mysterious Madame Blavatsky herself!"

Inordinate dependence on condescending and disparaging remarks about Indian leaders by British officials might make for interesting 'time-pass', but can hardly be considered authoritative. Early president of the Indian National Congress, W.C. Bonnerjee, in letters written during his sojourn in England, may have described Hinduism as a moribund religion and called India the most hateful land in the world, but surely his contribution to modern India's resurgence cannot be

summarised in these remarks alone. Similarly Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's disgust with the "babu culture" is not the sole reason why he is revered. Misra does not even mention *Vande Mataram* in her sketchy reference to his novel *Ananda Math*, which finds a place in her account only because she believes his hope of a Hindu army overpowering foreign conquerors almost materialised 150 years later.

Yet, for an anecdotal view of Raj history, *Vishnu's Crowded Temple* makes *chat-pata* reading. It recounts the basis of the British obsession with the racial characteristics of Indians, especially their disdain for the "effeminate" Bengali given to "masturbation" (the cause, apparently, for the high incidence of diabetes) and (who, therefore) could not stand up for himself against 'old dames' who took a particular delight in promoting sexual congress between the very young". Since

